

want to know that someone was willing to pay but couldn't, rather than to be left totally in the dark?

Unfortunately, many people who can't pay everything don't pay anything. That is also an error. Pay what you can each month, even if it's only a partial payment. And don't make unrealistic promises in order to get a creditor off your back. You need to approach a promise to pay with the same degree of caution that you would the signing of a contract. When you give your word, you need to keep it. If you make a promise when you know that you won't be able to meet the terms, you have violated the principle of vows. Listen to what the judge said about vows: "When you make a vow to God, do not delay in fulfilling it. He has no pleasure in fools; fulfill your vow. It is better not to vow than to make a vow and not fulfill it" (Ecclesiastes 5:4–1).

HAVE A WRITTEN PLAN

I have found consistently that creditors respond best to a specific request that is backed by a detailed plan in writing.

Most creditors have been deceived so many times by people making desperate promises that they have become calloused. Almost anyone under the threat of a court summons or wage attachment will make the appropriate promises. Consequently, most creditors have developed immunity to tearful pleas from delinquent debtors. However, most will respond to a written plan backed by guaranteed action on the part of a debtor.

That's why a financial coach is often necessary in dealing with belligerent creditors. A coach generally represents an objective third party who will enforce the agreements.

Step 1: A Detailed Report

You need to state in detail exactly how much you owe and what the minimum monthly requirements are. You can find helpful forms online.¹ The chart below reproduces one of those forms.